2026 Simson Debate Tournament Rulebook

Date prepared	October 6, 2026	Author	Matthew Sion Jeong

Part 1. Overview

This year's rulebook builds on last year's rules and newly establishes the Whip Speaker, revised POI rules, a per-category 100-point scoresheet, rules on signing, and rules on violations.

Rule 1 (Purpose) This rulebook sets out the tournament format, debate rules, scoring criteria, and the roles of the people who run the event, so that the Simson Debate Tournament is conducted fairly and consistently.

Rule 2 (Scope) This rulebook applies to all participating teams, judges, room supervisors, and organizing staff of the Elementary and Middle School Divisions.

Rule 3 (Debate Format) The tournament is based on the Asian Parliamentary Debate format, adjusted to suit Simson's regular debate classes and environment, and follows the special format and rules unique to the Simson Debate Tournament.

Rule 3-2 (Definitions)

1. Director: the Chair of the Tournament Host Committee.
2. Tournament Coordinator: the person who actually runs the tournament overall. The Tournament Coordinator manages the overall schedule.
3. Tournament Steering Committee: composed of all organizing staff listed in Rule 34.

Rule 4 (Changes This Year)

Item	Last year	This year
3rd Speaker	Reply Speaker	Whip Speaker (marked GW for Government, OW for Opposition)
Who may receive a POI	Not allowed against the Reply Speaker	Not allowed against the Whip Speaker
Accepting a POI	No rule	The first POI cannot be declined; later POIs proceed only if the speaker accepts
POI window	After 1 minute into the speech	From the 1:00 mark to before the 2:30 mark
Restriction on returning to seat after a POI	Even if a speech ended before 1 minute, the student who offered the POI could not return to their seat until 1 minute had passed	Deleted
Grace time	None	30 seconds after the end of a speech; no penalty; anything beyond that is not recorded

Item	Last year	This year
Preparation and speech time	3-minute speeches, 20 minutes of preparation	Unchanged
Tiebreakers for the final	Total points, then average age	Average score in valid rounds, then team totals of Preliminary Rounds 3, 2, and 1, in that order
Scoring criteria	67-83 points per speech, 9-band rubric	Logic 50 + Delivery 25 + Role 25 = speaker total of 100 points; team total of 300 points
Signing the scoresheet	No rule	A signed scoresheet cannot be reversed
Violations and reports	No rule	Newly established (Part 5)
Orientation	30 minutes	15 minutes

Part 2. Tournament Format

The tournament is held separately for the Elementary Division (5th floor) and the Middle School Division (6th floor). Teams are divided into Leagues A and B and debate in three preliminary rounds, and the top team in each league meets in the final to decide the champion.

Rule 5 (Participating Teams)

1. Teams consist of three students per team, formed by campus.
2. For the Elementary Division only, teams are formed so that the ratio of Pre-middle school students to elementary students is balanced. This does not apply to the Middle School Division.

Rule 6 (League Assignment)

1. Teams that advance to the main tournament are assigned to League A or League B.
2. When two or more teams from one campus advance, they must be placed in different leagues, and all of them may not be placed in the same league. Each campus assigns its leagues arbitrarily, without prior information such as other teams' league assignments, and delivers the assignment directly to the Tournament Coordinator.
3. If only one team from a campus advances, its league is assigned randomly.
4. Assigning leagues in consultation with other campuses is prohibited.
5. If the number of teams is unbalanced between leagues, the Tournament Coordinator may adjust it at their discretion, taking fairness into account.

Rule 7 (Draw Sheet)

1. Teams in each league are paired randomly, and this process is conducted openly with all campuses observing.
2. The draw sheet is announced in advance. Once completed, it cannot be changed.
3. On the draw sheet, the team on the left is Government (proposition) and the team on the right is Opposition. This applies to Preliminary Round 1 only.

Rule 8 (Preliminary Rounds)

1. There are three preliminary rounds.
2. Preliminary Round 1 is a prepared debate on a motion that is set and announced in advance. Sides are determined beforehand according to the draw sheet.
3. Preliminary Rounds 2 and 3 are impromptu debates on a motion randomly chosen from an announced list of motions. In the room, the two teams play rock-paper-scissors, and the winning team chooses the side.

Rule 9 (Advancing to the Final)

1. In each league, the team with the most wins over the three preliminary rounds advances to the final.
2. If teams are tied on wins, the team with the higher average score in valid rounds advances. Valid rounds are defined in Part 5, Rule 29.
3. If average scores are also tied, the team with the higher team total in Preliminary Round 3 advances. If that is also tied, compare Round 2, and if still tied, Round 1. A round that was void for either of the two teams (Rule 29) is skipped.

Rule 9-2 (Announcing the Finalists) The Tournament Coordinator announces the finalist teams and the final motion.

Rule 10 (Final)

1. The final is an impromptu debate, and its motion is decided by the Director. Motions not included in the Simson Debate Book may also be used.
2. The winner of the final is decided by a majority of the three-judge panel (the team supported by two or more judges wins). The judges convey the result to the Director, and the Director announces it.
3. The final panel consists of three judges from among the tournament's judges who do not belong to the campuses of the finalist teams. Reserve judges for the final are also designated by the Tournament Coordinator under the same standard.

Rule 11 (Preliminary Motions)

1. Preliminary motions are taken from the motions covered in this year's Simson Debate Book.
2. A-level motions are used mainly, but B-level motions are also included to allow participation at various levels.
3. The list of motions is announced before the tournament.

Rule 12 (Judge Assignment)

1. The Tournament Coordinator assigns judges according to the draw sheet.
2. A judge from the same campus as a team is not assigned to that team's debates.
3. Where possible, the same judge is not assigned to the same team's debates more than once. An exception is made where this is unavoidable.

Rule 13 (Win and Loss) The team with the most points wins; there are no low-point wins. The two teams' totals cannot be equal. The judge first decides which team won the key clashes, then scores so that the winning team's total is higher.

Rule 13-2 (Default Win)

1. If a team cannot play because its three members are not all present by the start time of the round (lateness or absence) or because it withdraws, the opposing team wins by default.
2. A default win counts toward wins but is excluded from score calculations (Rule 29).

Part 3. Debate Rules

Preparation is 20 minutes, and each speech is 3 minutes (plus 30 seconds of grace time). POIs may be offered to speakers other than the Whip Speaker, and only between the 1:00 and 2:30 marks of a speech.

Rule 14 (Speaker Roles) Each team has three speakers, and their titles and roles differ depending on side and speaking order.

	1st Speaker	2nd Speaker	3rd Speaker
Government	Prime Minister (PM): defines the motion and presents the main arguments	Deputy PM: rebuts and presents additional arguments	Whip Speaker (GW): identifies the key issues and summarizes
Opposition	Leader of Opposition (LO): rebuts and presents the main arguments	Deputy LO: rebuts and presents additional arguments	Whip Speaker (OW): identifies the key issues and summarizes

The Whip Speaker may not present new arguments.

Rule 15 (Preparation Time and Speech Time)

1. After the motion of each round is announced, 20 minutes of preparation time are given. For the final, preparation time is 30 minutes for both the Elementary and Middle School Divisions.
2. Each speech is 3 minutes long.
3. After each speech, the next speaker is given 1 minute of rebuttal preparation time.
4. Grace time: after 3 minutes, a speaker may finish within 30 seconds without penalty. Anything said after 3:30 is no longer recorded and is not reflected in scoring.
5. Judges act as timekeepers during the debate and signal time with a bell; the overall schedule is run by the Tournament Coordinator. One stroke is given at 1:00 (POIs begin), two strokes at 2:30 (POIs end), and the end of the speech is signaled at 3:00.

Rule 16 (POI, Point of Information)

1. A POI may be offered only to 1st and 2nd Speakers, not to the Whip Speaker (GW, OW). Only students on the opposing team may offer a POI.
2. A POI is offered to the speaker by standing, and proceeds if the speaker accepts. The first POI in paragraph 3 is an exception.

3. A speaker may not decline the first POI offered to them outside protected time (the first POI). The second and later POIs may be declined.
4. A POI must be a short question of no more than 15 seconds.
5. A POI may be offered only between the 1:00 and 2:30 marks of a speech (1:00-2:30). Time before and after this window is protected time.
6. The speech clock does not stop during a POI and its answer.
7. If a speaker declines the first POI, the judge reflects this in the Role score (Rule 21).

Rule 17 (Materials and Equipment)

1. The use of any materials prepared in advance (printouts, notes, handwritten materials, etc.) is prohibited. Preliminary Round 1 is the only exception.
2. Only the A4 memo paper provided on site just before the round may be brought in.
3. Electronic dictionaries are prohibited; only printed dictionaries are allowed.
4. Stopwatches with only a time display function are allowed. However, all electronic devices, including mobile phones, must be turned off and handed in just before the round.
5. If a prohibited item is found during a round, the team loses its eligibility to participate in the tournament.

Part 4. Scoring Criteria

Every speech is scored with Logic (50), Delivery (25), and Role (25) for a speaker total of 100 points, and the team total (300 points) is the sum of the three speaker totals. The winning team must always have the higher team total.

Rule 18 (Score Structure)

1. The judge scores each speaker in three categories: Logic 50 points, Delivery 25 points, and Role 25 points. The sum of the three categories is the speaker total (maximum 100 points).
2. The team total is the sum of the three speakers' speaker totals (maximum 300 points).
3. Only a speaker who did not speak receives 0 in all three categories.

Rule 19 (Scoring Rubric)

The rubric below follows the Instructions to Judges.

Band	Logic (50)	Delivery (25)	Role (25)
Excellent	45-50: Wins the key clashes with insightful arguments; every argument has full AREL.	23-25: Every word clear; compelling throughout.	23-25: Does the job of the position very well; skillful POIs, rebuttals and teamwork.
Good	39-44: Addresses the key clashes; AREL mostly complete, with minor gaps.	20-22: Clear and persuasive; holds attention.	20-22: Does the job well; effective POIs and rebuttals; consistent with the team.

Band	Logic (50)	Delivery (25)	Role (25)
Fair	33-38: Engages some clashes; AREL has gaps (thin evidence or missing link).	17-19: Mostly clear; some rushed, quiet or flat moments.	17-19: Does the basic job; some POIs and rebuttals; mostly consistent with the team.
Weak	26-32: Rarely engages the clashes; mostly assertion with basic reasoning.	13-16: Sometimes hard to follow; rarely convincing.	13-16: Job partly done; few POIs, limited rebuttal; uneven teamwork.
Very weak	0-25: Rarely relevant; bare assertions.	0-12: Often unclear; no attempt to persuade.	0-12: Little sense of the role; POIs ignored; little link with the team.

Category definitions: Logic concerns the arguments on the clash points, the key issues the teams disagree on, judged by AREL: Assertion (claim), Reasoning (why), Evidence (proof), and Link (to the clash and motion). Delivery covers enunciation (clear and easy to hear) and persuasion (confident and convincing). Role covers position duties (the job of the speaking position), POIs (offering and answering), rebuttals (answering the other side), and teamwork (fitting the team case).

Rule 20 (Scoring Method)

1. For each of the three categories, the judge picks the band that fits best and then scores within it: the middle for an average speech, higher if close to the band above, and lower if close to the band below.
2. The judge first decides which team won the key clashes and scores so that the winning team's team total is higher. If the two teams' totals become equal, the judge adjusts the scores before signing.
3. Each speaker is scored by the job of their own position, and nothing that a position does not include is penalized. The Government 1st Speaker (PM) builds the case and sets the team split, so Logic is judged on anticipating the likely clashes, and no rebuttal is expected. The 3rd Speaker (Whip) mostly summarizes and weighs the clashes, and new arguments are not expected.

Rule 21 (Evaluating POIs)

1. Offering and answering POIs is evaluated under the Role category, and there are no separate bonus or penalty points.
2. The Whip Speaker does not receive POIs, so not answering a POI is not penalized.
3. If a speaker declines the first POI, the judge reflects this in the Role score (Rule 16, paragraph 3).

Rule 22 (Completing and Signing the Scoresheet)

1. The judge enters on the scoresheet the tournament name, date, round, room, judge's name, motion, the names of both teams and the last names of the speakers, each speaker's Logic, Delivery, and Role scores and speaker total, the team totals, the winning team and its side, and comments.
2. The judge signs in the signature field and enters their campus.

3. Errors may be corrected before signing; after signing, the scoresheet cannot be reversed (Rule 23).
4. The room supervisor only checks the form of the scoresheet, namely missing signatures and whether any category score exceeds its maximum (Logic 50, Delivery 25, Role 25), and then delivers it to the operations office. The room supervisor may not get involved in scores or the result.

Rule 22-2 (Feedback and Announcing Results)

1. In Preliminary Rounds 1 and 2, during the feedback time after the debate, the judge announces the result and explains both teams' strengths and weaknesses and the reasons for the scores given.
2. Preliminary Round 3 is conducted without feedback.
3. The result of the final is announced by the Director under Rule 10.

Part 5. Violations and Reports

A signed scoresheet cannot be reversed. Only serious violations, namely forgery, signing on another's behalf, and collusion, are handled by the Tournament Steering Committee through re-judging from the recording or disqualification. Because there is no time to rerun a debate, debates are not rerun.

Rule 23 (No Reversal After Signing)

1. A scoresheet signed by a judge cannot be reversed. Dissatisfaction with the result of a round is not grounds for a report.
2. Forgery and signing on another's behalf make the signature itself invalid, so paragraph 1 does not apply.

Rule 24 (Types of Serious Violations)

1. Forgery: tampering with the scores, signature, or entries on a scoresheet.
2. Signing on another's behalf: signing by someone other than the judge.
3. Collusion: any act in which judges, teams, students, teachers, campus staff, or others agree or conspire in advance to fix the result or scores.

Rule 25 (Who Decides) The Tournament Steering Committee decides whether a violation occurred and how to handle it, and its decision is final.

Rule 26 (How Violations Are Handled)

Situation	Handling
A violation by a judge alone (bias, forgery, signing on another's behalf, etc.)	First priority: a replacement judge re-judges the debate from the recording. If re-judging is difficult before the finalists are announced, then, as a second priority, both teams are treated as winners. The judge involved is replaced immediately and excluded from later assignments.
Collusion between a judge and a team (students)	The team that colluded is disqualified from the entire tournament, and the opposing team wins by forfeit. The judge involved is replaced immediately and excluded from later assignments.

Situation	Handling
Only teachers or campus staff colluded with a judge (students did not know)	The debate is re-judged from the recording. Those involved are excluded from judge and room supervisor assignments, and their campus is notified. Whether the students knew is determined by the Tournament Steering Committee from the recording and statements.

Rule 27 (Reporting Procedure)

1. Only room supervisors and judges may file a report. Students and teams may report only through their supervising teacher.
2. A report concerns only violations and is submitted in writing before the round's scoresheet is delivered to the operations office. For the final, it may be submitted until before the award ceremony.
3. The Tournament Steering Committee decides after reviewing the recording and other evidence.

Rule 28 (False Reports) If a report is found to have been made knowingly when there was no violation, the reporting team forfeits that round.

Rule 29 (Handling of Scores)

1. A debate in which both teams were awarded a win, or which ended in a forfeit win or a default win, is treated as a void round and excluded from score calculations.
2. Under Rule 9, tiebreakers for advancing to the final apply in this order: wins, average score in valid rounds, then the team totals of Preliminary Rounds 3, 2, and 1.

Rule 30 (Special Rules for the Final) Joint wins are not recognized in the final.

1. If the verdict of the judge who committed the violation is set aside and the other two judges agree, the result is confirmed.
2. If the verdicts are split, a reserve judge decides after viewing the recording or the debate on site.
3. If a team's collusion is confirmed, that team is disqualified and the opposing team wins.

Rule 31 (Teacher Interference) During a debate, teachers may not coach or intervene in any way. If a teacher's coaching or intervention is reported and confirmed, the team that received help is disqualified immediately.

Part 6. Rules for Staff

Room supervisors, judges, and organizing staff perform only their assigned duties and may not coach or intervene in any way during a debate.

Rule 32 (Room Supervisors)

1. One teacher from each campus is assigned to each room, and room supervisors' room assignments are fixed. In principle, the room supervisor is the campus team leader; if that is not possible, the deputy team leader.
2. When assigning rooms according to the draw sheet, a teacher from the same campus as a team is not placed in that team's room.

3. The duties of room supervisors are as follows.

Duty	Details
Distribute hoodies, name tags, and leaflets	Organizing staff guide this at entry.
Manage Zoom and recording	Press the camera record button before and after each round.
Announce the motion and set up the board	The motion is announced via KakaoTalk. Write the motion and the speaker lineup on the board, and mark the 3rd Speaker as GW or OW.
Deliver scoresheets	After checking the signature and score ranges, deliver the scoresheet to the operations office (Rule 22).
Student movement and control	After each round, move students to the next room to rest. Control entry during rounds. Even if a round ends early, have students wait quietly in the room until the announcement.
Managing the meal	Lunch is eaten in the Round 2 room. The room supervisor eats with the students and then directs them to the next room as announced.

Rule 33 (Judges)

1. Judges score fairly under the scoring criteria in Part 4 and are responsible for their signatures. They also serve as timekeepers during the debate.
2. Judge training is conducted by the judge training lead.
3. During a debate, judges do not communicate with teams or teachers by any means other than the scoresheet.
4. A judge who commits a violation is handled under Part 5.

Rule 34 (Organizing Staff Roles) The table below is based on last year's assignees. This year's staff are largely the same, with only the judge training lead changing. Assignees will be updated once finalized.

Duty	Assignee (last year)
Overall tournament operations and planning	정시온
Judge training and communication	정시온 (this year: 유희상)
Tournament running and announcements	Elementary: 정시온; Middle School: 유희상
Entering certificates and preparing awards	Elementary: 유명혜; Middle School: 조원아
Collecting team results and calculating rankings	Elementary: 이현철; Middle School: 양길우
Video and photography	유현수
Facilities support (microphones, Zoom setup)	김영현

Duty	Assignee (last year)
Assigning Zoom numbers	양길우
Supplies support (hoodies, name tags, leaflets, trophies, meals)	유명혜
Overall support for the Middle School and Elementary Divisions	Elementary: 최은하; Middle School: 조원아

Rule 35 (Other)

1. Students bring writing instruments, a lunch box, and a tumbler.
2. Guidance for observing via Zoom is announced all at once by the director in charge.
3. Shuttle bus timetables are announced by each campus.

Part 7. Awards

Rule 36 (Awards)

Award	Recipient	Benefit
Champion	1st place team	100% tuition discount + trophy
Finalist	2nd place team	50% tuition discount + trophy
3rd Place	3rd place team	30% tuition discount + trophy
Simson Awards	The 3 highest individual scorers (including 1 Middle School student), excluding finalist teams, by summing speaker totals (maximum 100 points) in the preliminary rounds	20% tuition discount
Essay Awards	5 students observing the final	20 points
Coach incentive	Korean and native-speaker teachers who coached award-winning teams	Incentive paid

Appendix

A. Tournament Schedule

By shortening orientation from 30 to 15 minutes, the entire schedule is 15 minutes earlier than last year. The Elementary Division ends at 15:35 and the Middle School Division at 16:05. Assembly time is 10:30 for both divisions.

Item	Elementary	Middle School
Roll call, opening ceremony, orientation	10:30-10:45	11:00-11:15
Break	10:45-10:55	11:15-11:25
Preliminary Round 1 + feedback	10:55-11:25	11:25-11:55

Item	Elementary	Middle School
Break	11:25-11:35	11:55-12:05
Prep time	11:35-11:55	12:05-12:25
Preliminary Round 2 + feedback	11:55-12:25	12:25-12:55
Lunch (Round 2 room)	12:25-12:55	12:55-13:25
Prep time	12:55-13:15	13:25-13:45
Preliminary Round 3 (no feedback)	13:15-13:45	13:45-14:15
Break	13:45-13:55	14:15-14:25
Announcement of finalists and final motion	13:55-14:05	14:25-14:35
Final prep time	14:05-14:35	14:35-15:05
Final	14:35-15:05	15:05-15:35
Award ceremony and closing remarks	15:05-15:35	15:35-16:05

It is proposed to split the 15-minute orientation into 5 minutes for roll call, 3 minutes for opening remarks, and 7 minutes for announcements. The announcements should include this year's changes: the POI window (1:00-2:30) and the grace time.

B. Items to Be Finalized

1. Whether Pre-middle school students may participate in the Middle School Division: to be reflected in Rule 5 once decided.
2. Final handling of ties for advancing to the final: how to resolve a tie when even the team totals of Preliminary Rounds 3, 2, and 1 are all equal (for example, a public draw) has not been decided.
3. Details of the POI rules (Rule 16): whether a Whip Speaker may offer a POI (currently yes), and how declining the first POI affects scores (currently reflected in the Role category) must be finalized.
4. This year's motion for Preliminary Round 1 and the list of motions for Rounds 2 and 3 must be finalized based on this year's Simson Debate Book.
5. This year's number of participating teams and league composition: last year there were 18 Elementary teams (League A 8, League B 10) and 12 Middle School teams (League A 6, League B 6).
6. The number of judges for preliminary rounds (1 or 3) and the number of reserve judges for the final (2 recommended).
7. This year's organizing staff assignees and room supervisor assignments: the staff are largely the same as last year, with only the judge training lead changing. Room supervisors are the campus team leaders, or the deputy team leaders if that is not possible. The lists must be updated once finalized.